

Crime **RUCHIKA'S SUICIDE**

IN HER OWN WORDS

Mr Rathore caught hold of my hand. He pressed his body against mine. I tried getting rid of Mr Rathore by pushing him away with one hand which Mr Rathore was not holding. I was shocked and became nervous with the behaviour of Mr Rathore. In the mean time Reemu (Aradhana Gupta) came into the room and on seeing her Mr Rathore released me and fell down in his chair. Mr Rathore asked Reemu to go out of his room and bring Mr Thomas, the coach, with her. But she refused and then Mr Rathore rebuked Reemu loudly, asking her to bring the coach, Mr Thomas. Mr Rathore insisted that I stay in his room but I ran out. I told Reemu whatever Mr Rathore had done. She had also seen Mr Rathore misbehaving with me. I was so afraid and nervous that I asked Reemu what we should do now. We were afraid that since Mr Rathore is the Inspector General of Police, he may involve or harass our parents. Therefore, we decided not to inform our parents or anybody else about the incident. On August 13, we did not go to play. Next day, we went to play tennis and when we were leaving, the ball picker Mr Paltoo said Mr Rathore was calling me again. It was then that we decided to inform our parents. Reemu narrated the incident to my father and after that I went to her house and told her mother, Madhu.

From Ruchika's statement recorded by DGP R.R. Singh in 1990

WHAT NEXT

- The Parkash family can seek a retrial, adding Section 306 of the IPC for abetment to suicide.
- Ruchika's family is still hesitant to come out in the open, and hopes that the court will take notice and intervene in the case.
- Parkash's lawyer Pankaj Bhardwaj says a retrial will be possible only through media-inspired public pressure.

was too light and social activists demanding a retrial.

But then the case seemed doomed from the start, when despite an inquiry by then director general of police (DGP) R.R. Singh holding Rathore prima facie guilty of molesting Ruchika and his recommendation to the state government that a case be registered against him, chief minister Hukam Singh of the Indian National Lok Dal (INLD) ignored it. Rathore, now 68, was even promoted as the additional DGP in 1994 when Bhajan Lal was the chief minister. It was just a few months after Ruchika committed suicide. Five years later, the INLD government led by Om Prakash Chautala made him the DGP of the state, where he stayed on till December 2000, despite the CBI chargesheeting him in the molestation case in January the same year.

Such was Rathore's clout that he even managed to thwart efforts to lodge an FIR against him. On May 28, 1991, the Government okayed filing of a chargesheet against him but even that didn't happen till June 30, 1992, when Legal Remembrancer R.K. Nehru said that the Haryana government was not competent to issue a chargesheet to Rathore and it would be appropriate to get an FIR registered instead. That didn't happen. For several months even the case file went missing from the government records though it was found later.

In all this, Rathore was not suspended for a single day. Instead, Ruchika's family was harassed unrelentingly. Eleven cases were filed against her brother, Ashu, then 16, and now a transporter in Panchkula. Her father, Subhash Chander Girhotra, now 68, Rathore's exact age, a manager with the Oriental Bank of Commerce, was threatened, harassed in office and left with no choice but to quit. He was forced to sell his Sector 6 house after Ruchika filed a complaint with the police, seeking registration of a molestation case. Goons would man their locality and their house would be attacked with stones. Ruchika was stalked and even rusticated from Sacred Heart Convent School on grounds of "indiscipline".

KESHAV SINGH



ARADHANA, A CLOSE FRIEND OF RUCHIKA, IS NOT GIVING UP

Almost a prisoner in her own home, her family in ruins, her gleaming sporting future shattered, Ruchika felt there was nothing to live for, recalls Aradhana. "More than what happened to her, she was bothered about what her brother and father were passing through. She felt responsible for all that." She committed suicide on December 28, 1993. "I was busy with my BA exams and hadn't spoken to her for some days," says Aradhana, still shaking her head at the waste of a young life. Her family went underground, not even accessible to the Parkashes. Even Aradhana and her father were not spared. "When I was doing my MBA in